Periodicals

H 1927

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A. Background

LC practice: As stated in H 1075, LC catalogers will no longer use form subdivisions. Instead assign an appropriate term or terms from Library of Congress Genre/Form Terms (LCGFT), e.g. ***Catalogs***. To replace a form subdivision that includes a demographic group, also assign Library of Congress Demographic Groups Terms (LCDGT) to bring out the audience of the resource being cataloged, e.g. ***German speakers*** or ***Arabic, Students of***.

For guidelines on assigning LCGFT to periodicals, see the LCGFT Manual J243.

For guidelines on catalogs of periodicals, see H 1361. For guidelines on electronic serials, see H 1580.5. For guidelines on indexes to periodicals, see H 1670. For guidelines on newspapers on special topics and newspapers of ethnic groups in the United States, see H 1920. For guidelines on classification of periodicals, see F 210 and F 220.

B. Recent revisions

2026-08: Updated template. Added instructions related to LCGFT implementation.

C. Definitions

Periodicals: a publication other than a newspaper that is actually or purportedly issued according to a regular schedule (monthly, quarterly, biennially, etc.) in successive parts, each of which bears a numerical or chronological designation, and that is intended to be continued indefinitely.

Note: This definition is broader than the traditional definition, which states that a periodical is generally published more frequently than annually and normally contains separate articles.

Serials: used in a broad sense to refer to any title cataloged as a serial, including periodicals, newspapers, monographic series, etc.

D. General rule

Use ***--Periodicals*** as a form subdivision under all headings assigned to works that conform to the definition of periodicals given above, including annual reports. Use this subdivision under topical headings, personal name headings, corporate body headings, geographic headings, etc., without restriction.

LC practice: Assign subject headings to bring out the topic of the periodical. Also assign LCGFT appropriate to the form and/or genre of the resource in hand, e.g. LCGFT ***Periodicals***.

D.1. Regularity of publication

When a resource's frequency cannot be determined, assign the form subdivision ***--Periodicals*** using cataloger's judgement. Base this judgment on whether or not the periodical appears to be issued regularly. In case of doubt, assume that it is issued regularly and assign the form subdivision ***--Periodicals***.

If a publication is known to be issued irregularly but contains articles, etc., and in all other ways appears to be a periodical as defined above, assign the form subdivision ***--Periodicals***

LC practice: Use judgment to determine the frequency, as described above. As appropriate, assign LCGFT appropriate to the form and/or genre of the resource in hand, e.g. LCGFT ***Periodicals***.

D.2. Juvenile periodicals

When using this form subdivision ***--Periodicals*** in conjunction with the form subdivision ***--Juvenile literature***, construct the heading as follows:

Model:

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[topic]--Periodicals--Juvenile literature.
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LC practice: Do not use either form subdivision. Assign LCDGT to identify the intended audience, e.g. LCDGT ***Children***. Assign LCGFT appropriate to the form and/or genre of the resource in hand, e.g. LCGFT ***Periodicals***.

D.3 Serials that are not periodicals

Do not use the form subdivision under headings assigned to publications that are revised and reissued in full on a regular basis, and are therefore cataloged as serials for convenience, but are not periodicals as defined above. For example, *Library of Congress Subject Headings* was published annually and is cataloged as a serial, but the subdivision ***--Periodicals*** is inappropriate for this work.

D.4 Monographic series

Do not use the form subdivision under headings assigned to monographic series.

E. --Periodicals under form headings and other form subdivisions

Use the form subdivision ***--Periodicals*** as a further subdivision under most form headings and form subdivisions, for example, ***American poetry--Periodicals; *Tuberculosis--Statistics--Periodicals***.

LC practice: Assign the subject heading for the form when it is needed to bring out language, nationality, or ethnicity. Also assign LCGFT appropriate to the form and/or genre of the resource in hand, e.g. LCGFT ***Poetry*** and/or ***Periodicals***.

E.1. Exception

Do not use the form subdivision *--**Periodicals*** as a further subdivision under the following form subdivisions:

- Amateurs' manual
- Atlases
- Calendars
- Cases
- Congress
- Databases
- Dictionaries
- Digests
- Directories
- Encyclopedias
- Gazetteers

- Guidebooks
- Handbooks, manuals, etc.
- Juvenile films
- Juvenile literature
- Juvenile sound recordings
- Juvenile sound recordings
- Laboratory manuals
- Maps
- Newspapers
- Observers' manuals
- Outlines, syllabi, etc.
- Photo maps
- Registers
- Telephone directories

F. Works about periodicals

Use ***--Periodicals*** also as a topical subdivision for general works that discuss periodicals on a specific subject. Do not further subdivide by ***--History and criticism***. For works on the history of periodicals on a specific subject, the subdivision ***--History*** may be used. For bibliographies, catalogs, indexes, union lists, etc., of periodicals further subdivide ***--Periodicals*** by the appropriate form subdivision. However, for a bibliography of periodical *articles* on a topic, assign ***[topic]--Bibliography*** without interposing the subdivision ***--Periodicals***.

LC practice: For works about periodicals, assign ***--Periodicals*** as a topical subdivision. Assign LCGFT appropriate to the form and/or genre of the resource in hand, e.g. LCGFT ***Bibliographies***.

Revision history

2026-08: Updated template. Added instructions related to LCGFT implementation.